

HONG WANG

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Appointments

Harvard University, Department of Economics *Aug. 2026–Mar. 2027*
Mary Beth and Chris Gordon Postdoctoral Fellow in Gender Inequality

Education

Boston University *Sep. 2020–Aug. 2026*

Ph.D. in Economics

M.A. in Political Economy *Aug. 2024*

New York University *May 2018*

B.A. in Mathematics and Economics, *cum laude*

Fields

Primary Fields: Economic History, Political Economy

Secondary Fields: Gender Economics, Media Economics

Methods: Historical Data Construction, Natural Language Processing, Deep Learning, Geospatial Analysis

References

Martin Fiszbein

Boston University
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James Feigenbaum

Boston University
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Robert Margo

Boston University
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Claudia Goldin

Harvard University
cgoldin@harvard.edu

Melissa Dell

Harvard University
melissadell@fas.harvard.edu

Research

Research Assistant to James Feigenbaum, Boston University *2022–2023*

Teaching

Teaching Fellow, Introductory Microeconomics and Macroeconomics, Boston University *2021–2025*

Job Market Paper

What Killed the ERA? The Role of Entrepreneurs in the Marketplace of Ideas and Policy

Despite overwhelming congressional support amid a feminist resurgence, the Equal Rights Amendment (ERA) died three states short of ratification by 1982. Exploiting topographic and geochemical variation in exposure to the CBS program *Spectrum*, I show that in Illinois, Phyllis Schlafly's FM broadcasts reduced legislators' ERA support by 18.4 pp, while AM and TV increased adoption of her anti-ERA framing. Across ERA battleground states, her FM broadcasts reduced pro-women's-rights sentiment, suggesting how a cultural entrepreneur helped kill the ERA.

Working Papers

Grounded: Soil Geochemistry and the Causal Effects of Political AM Radio

Did radio change interwar politics, or did the signal get mismeasured? I show that canonical AM radio studies use ITM, a topographic model for line-of-sight FM and TV, rather than LFMM, which models AM ground-wave attenuation through soil conductivity. The physical correction changes the conclusions. LFMM reverses the estimated Coughlin–Roosevelt relationship in the United States, but strengthens the Nazi-radio estimate in Germany, where fixed effects absorb the mismatch. Geochemical instruments show stronger Coughlin signals causally reduced Roosevelt’s vote share, while Nazi AM radio availability did not increase Nazi vote share.

A Republic, Not a Democracy: The Legacy of John Birch Society Membership

Economic decline and demographic threat dominate explanations of contemporary right-wing mobilization, but older right-wing organizations are rarely measured directly. I use newly digitized John Birch Society rolls, recovering 45,188 records from 1,870 archival pages, to measure county-level right-wing infrastructure in the 1980s. JBS presence predicts DOJ-charged January 6 defendants and weakens manufacturing-decline explanations, but not the swing toward Trump or diffuse right-wing terrorism.

A Choice, Not an Echo: Cultural Matching in the Marketplace of Ideas and Policy

Why do old political arguments suddenly become powerful? I propose *cultural matching*: arguments activate only when dormant stock, unmet demand, and a scarce matcher align. Since the stock of ideas and demand can build quietly while matchers remain rare, political change can look sudden—as anti-ERA politics did in the 1970s.

Papers in Progress

The Evangelical Origins of the Welfare Queen *with Brianna Alderman and Gabby Toborg*

Using Christian media exposure, we study whether substitution between private charity and public welfare created incentives for churches to advocate against the welfare state by turning congregational sentiment against welfare recipients.

Deep Learning for Census Linking *with Abhishek Arora and James Feigenbaum*

Using Sentence-BERT, we develop cosine-similarity methods to improve name-variant disambiguation over time for historical census record linkage.

Seminars & Conferences

Harvard University, Economic History Graduate Workshop	2023, 2024, 2025
London School of Economics, Queer Conference	2025

Research Grants

BU Institute for Economic Development Research Grant, Boston University, \$3,000	2025
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Academic Service

Organizer, BU–Harvard Summer Deep Learning in Economics Reading Group	Summer 2024
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Languages, Software Skills, and Citizenship

Languages: English, Italian, Portuguese

Software Skills: Python, PyTorch, QGIS, L^AT_EX

Citizenship: United States